

A Paranoiac's Pen Drive!

Kingston recently released a pen drive for the paranoid. The Kingston Data Traveler Elite Privacy Edition thumb drive has a capacity of 4 GB, 128-bit AES encryption, and the ability to erase itself if the wrong password is entered more than 25 times! Data was probably never this secure!



XP On Mac Proved Possible

According to the "Windows XP on Mac" Web site—www.winxp-on-mac.com—a hacker called "narf" successfully managed to load Windows XP on an unmodified Intel-based Apple Mac. Apple engineers, as recently as early March, had said this was impossible!



Escape

HACKED IN HALF AN HOUR

Macs Easier To Exploit?

In what turned out to be an exercise in how to insert foot in mouth, a Swedish Mac fan set up a Mac Mini as a Web server and challenged the hackers of the world to "try and gain root control." Less than six hours later, the box was compromised, and the site it was serving defaced with the message "This sucks. Six hours later this poor little Mac was owned and this page got defaced."

The hacker, who goes by the nickname "Gwerdna," later told ZDNet that he achieved the hack in less than 30 minutes. He claims to have first looked for some obvious flaws, after which he proceeded to attack the box through an undocumented exploit that Apple has no patch for yet! Whether or not this is just hot air we don't really

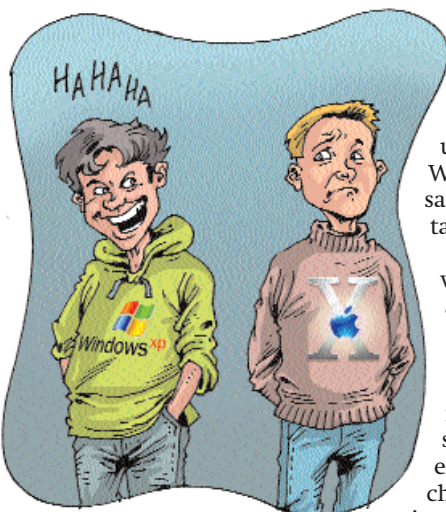
know, but the fact is that the Mac OS box was compromised in a matter of hours after the challenge was thrown out.

Considering that Mac OS has one of the smallest subscriber bases around, not too many hackers are interested in even trying

out their skills on a Mac box. This is what makes the news of the hack even worse for Apple! If hardly any hackers are training to hack Macs, and the Mac Mini was still hacked so quickly, not much can be said for security on Apple's OS.

Many believe that even a Windows box could have held out longer! So is the Mac going to become the new Windows? Well, not unless it can match Windows in terms of sales as well, which is a tall order.

Another thing we were left wondering about is that if the Mac OS is based on the FreeBSD OS, which is considered one of the most secure operating systems around, what exactly have Apple changed, and more importantly, why?



Illustrations: Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

Whatever Happened To...

The Simputer?

Five years ago, we all were regaled by the wonderful story of the Simple, Inexpensive, Multilingual People's Computer—the Simputer. Developed in India, it was the sure recipe to bring affordable computing to the masses—yes, even the rural masses. "Illiteracy is no longer a barrier to handling a computer," the Simputer Trust claimed, and the rest of us went, "Ooooooh!"

Constructed like a PDA—with a touchscreen and stylus and everything—the Simputer runs on Linux (of course—affordable, you know), has an Intel StrongARM 206 MHz processor, 64 MB of RAM, 32 MB of Flash memory, and can read smartcards. The simple interface based on graphics and audio was to make it illiteracy-proof. All this at only Rs 9,000 if bought in bulk. And five years ago, this seemed foolproof.

Though it's been out of the limelight, the Simputer still exists and is used minimally. All is not well, though. There's more to a great product than a great concept, and thanks to some less-than-optimal marketing, the Simputer sold only a little over 4,000 units after its release. The sad story is that with other forms of portable computing getting cheaper, the Simputer is already fighting a losing battle, though it might still stand a chance in the villages.

What happens now? Are we witnessing the slow demise of the Simputer, or is it lurking in the background waiting to take us by storm?

Win! My Desktop

No Winner This Month! Of the many entries that we received, only a few followed the new rules—and there was no winner among them, either! We've seen you make great desktops, so why not tell your fellow readers about them?

We want to know exactly how the desktop was created. As usual, no theme packs, please! Using a shell enhancement is all right, as long as you've customised it *yourself*.

Remember, if we can't recreate your desktop the way you describe it, the entry will be rejected, so please be clear!



Send your desktop with description of how you made it to mydesktop@thinkdigit.com with the subject 'My Desktop' and tell us your postal address, too.